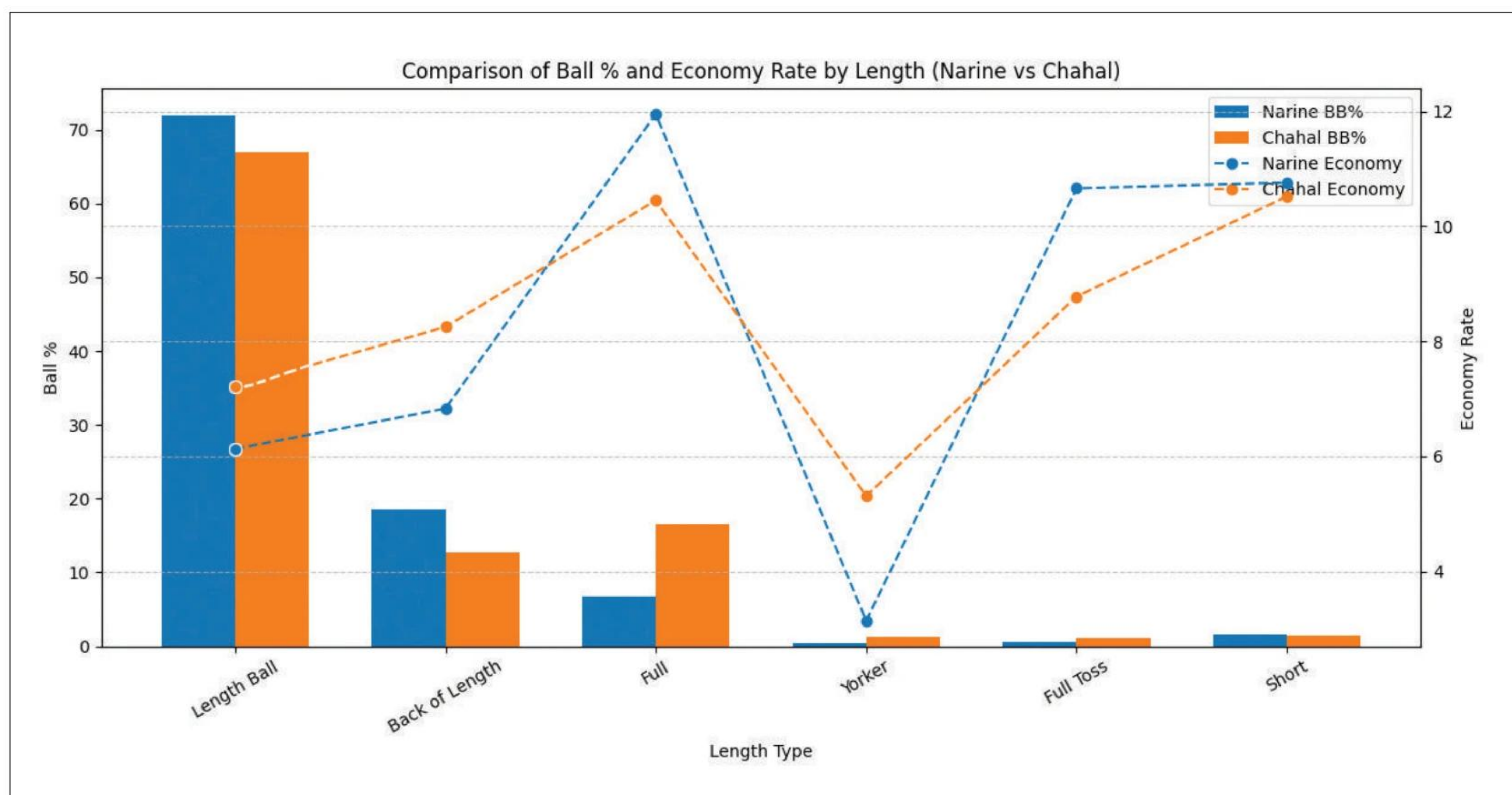




Chakaravarthy and Rathi follow a similar template. Both bowl back of a length, keep the stumps in play, and use a flatter trajectory for each variation.

“Length is very important,” says Harbhajan. “If you bowl Test-match lengths, batters will slog without caring where it’s turning. But if it’s slightly shorter — like Varun or Narine bowl — it’s neither too full nor too short. Batters get stuck. You can’t go back and pull, or come forward and slog.” (See **Foot movement table — Graph 4**)

In this IPL season alone, batters trying to play these three spinners on the front foot have been dismissed 16 times — mostly while playing attacking shots. Playing them on the back foot is safer, though it only yields 6.35 runs per over. Their quicker pace also makes it harder to step out.

What’s the Shelf Life of a Mystery?

In the age of high-speed cameras, detailed video footage, and data analysis, mystery spinners don’t stay mysterious for long.

Mendis’ carrom balls were decoded. Narine faced a career dip after multiple action-related suspensions. Batters evolve fast, analysing every detail to exploit even

Varun Chakaravarathy's variations in IPL over the years

Variation	Balls Bowled	Eco	Wks
leg spinner	958	8.21	41
slider	13	12.92	0
googly	564	6.12	43
quicker ball	174	7.55	5
top spinner	11	3.27	3
flipper	25	6.24	1
arm ball	1	6.00	0
off break	4	4.50	0

Foot movement against Narine, Varun, and Digvesh in IPL 2025

Foot Movement	Ball %	False Shot %	Attack%	Wickets
back foot	48.03 (219)	17.40	43.70	8
front foot	47.37 (216)	22.70	61.80	16
moves in front	1.97 (9)	30.00	80.00	0
down the track	1.32 (6)	33.30	33.30	2
backs away	1.32 (6)	50.00	50.00	0

a minor giveaway.

Author Julia Cameron once said, “Mystery is at the heart of creativity. That, and surprise.” As T20 cricket continues to evolve, so too must its bowlers.

The moment one puzzle is solved, another needs to be posed.

That might be the real mystery: what’s next?

(Data till IPL 2025
Match 33 — MI vs SRH)